



All smiles: Sifan Hassan during the medal ceremony of the women's marathon event.
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Stars of the show

As far as its own performance is concerned, France finished fifth on the medal tally with 16 gold, 26 silver and 22 bronze medals. It is its second-best showing at a single edition.

French swimmer Leon Marchand became the toast of the nation as he bagged four out of those 16 gold medals. All four gold medals for the 22-year-old Marchand came with new Olympic Records, including an incredible double in 200m breaststroke and butterfly events on the same night.

The "Marchand Mania" had reached such a level where the news of his triumphs at the Paris La Defense Arena in Nanterre resulted in celebrations at other venues. Decathlon's 400m event at the Stade

de France could not begin on time due to the same reason. No wonder that Marchand, who lit a fire under the rest of the French contingent, was chosen to carry the Olympic flame during the closing ceremony.

For the US, which topped the medal table for the 19th time, two 27-year-olds stood out even as a bunch of new athletes also made their mark. Simone Biles had faced mental health issues and the "twisties" at the Tokyo Olympics but in Paris, the gymnast was back at her impressive best. She clinched two individual gold and one silver medals apart from the women's team gold. She is now the joint second-most decorated female gymnast of all time at the Olympics with 11 medals, tied with Věra Čáslavská, who participated for erstwhile Czechoslovakia, and

only behind Larisa Latynina of the Soviet Union, who won 18 medals. Katie Ledecky continued her dominance over 800m and 1500m freestyle while also bagging a silver and a bronze in Paris, becoming the most decorated female Olympic swimmer of all-time with a total medal haul of 14.

Sifan Hassan, an Ethiopian-born Dutch runner, defied the odds to potentially emerge as the biggest story from athletics. The 31-year-old middle/long-distance runner became only the second athlete in Olympic history after Emil Zatopek in 1952 to win medals in 5000m, 10,000m and the marathon. While Hassan bagged bronze in the first two events, her gold in marathon was particularly impressive as she set a new Olympic record after a sprint to the finish line with Ethiopia's Tigst Assefa chasing her. Novak Djokovic, bidding to become the fifth player after Steffi Graf, Andre Agassi, Rafael Nadal and Serena Williams to achieve the Career Golden Slam, finally found the missing piece of the puzzle. The 37-year-old Serbian, just three weeks after a demoralising defeat in the Wimbledon final to rising star Carlos Alcaraz, got redemption as he beat the Spaniard 7-6(3), 7-6(2) for the men's singles gold medal.

Upsets aplenty

An event that is held once every four years leaves plenty of scope for upsets and Paris 2024 was no different.

Host France shocked two-time men's Rugby Sevens champion Fiji 28-7 to win its first gold of the Games. Fiji had a 17-0 win-loss record at the Olympics coming into the final.

Both the women's 100m and men's 200m sprint events at Stade de France not only ended with first-ever gold medals for the winners as well as their countries but at the same time, it also left the spectators stunned at the manner in which the heavy favourites lost. Julien Alfred put Saint Lucia, a small island-nation, on the world map as she easily defeated USA's Sha'Carri Richardson to become the new 'Sprint Queen.' In men's 200m, it was Botswana's Letsile